SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA

ASSESSING SUSTAINABILITY PRACTICES OF SOCIAL ENTERPRISES IN AGUSAN DEL NORTE

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By

SANDARA G. LORETO

MARY ROSE O. CAMANIAN

HAZEL MAE B. DOÑAHAN

KURT RYAN R. EDRADAN

SAMEERA SHANE B. GALLARDO

JUDY COR L. HERMOSO

ADVISER: KAYE H. ABIAN, MM, CMMS

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SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA
College Of Business Management

CERTIFICATE OF RESEARCH APPROVAL

This thesis entitled **"ASSESSING SUSTAINABILITY PRACTICES OF SOCIAL ENTERPRISES IN AGUSAN DEL NORTE"** presented and submitted by Sandara G. Loreto, Mary Rose O. Camanian, Hazel Mae B. Doñahan, Kurt Ryan R. Edradan, Sameera Shane B. Gallardo, Judy Cor L. Hermoso. in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of Bachelor of Science in Business Administration Major in Financial Management is hereby accepted and recommended for Oral Examination.

KAYE H. ABIAN, MM, CMMS
Adviser

GARY CRIS S. PELEGRINO, DBA
Member

NOEL S. BITANCOR, CFMP, MPA (CAR)
Member

RUSSELLENE B. CORAZA, DBA
Member

REGGY H. BARTIDO, CREA
Member

ERLY C. BASALO, LPT
Member

BEVERLY D. JAMINAL, ED. D
Chairperson

ACCEPTED as partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of Bachelor of Science in Business Administration Major in Financial Management.

APPROVED by the tribunal at the Oral Examination with the grade of _____.

KAYE H. ABIAN, MM, CMMS
Adviser

GARY CRIS R. PELEGRINO, DBA
Member

NOEL S. BITANCOR, CFMP, MPA (CAR)
Member

RUSSELLENE B. CORAZA, DBA
Member

REGGY H. BARTIDO, CREA
Member

ERLY C. BASALO, LPT
Member

BEVERLY D. JAMINAL, ED. D
Chairperson

SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA
Nasipit, Agusan del Norte
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CHAPTER 1

THE PROBLEM AND ITS SCOPE

1.1 Background of the study

Social enterprises are organizations that strive to create both social and financial value by using business models to achieve these two goals at the same time (Tykkyläinen et al., 2021). By addressing social challenges, they also help advance the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). Their mission-focused goals, innovative strategies, commitment to empowerment and inclusion, and collaboration with partners make them strong advocates of sustainable development (Quaye et al., 2024). Beyond promoting sustainability, social enterprises also help communities by creating jobs, supporting local businesses, and addressing issues such as poverty and inequality (Toheeb et al., 2025).

International studies show that sustainability has become an ethical responsibility and strategic essential for organizations. According to Maheshwari (2024), guided by Ellkington's (1997) Triple Bottom Line framework, true success is based on a balanced between profit, people, and planet. Sustainable practices not only enhance organizational performance and public trust but also face obstacles such as high costs and limited consumer awareness. The study recommended adopting circular economy models and fostering innovation to support long-term growth and community welfare.

Social enterprises play a critical role in advancing sustainability by introducing innovative, eco-friendly products, responsible marketing strategies, and effective waste management practices, even with limited resources (Harsanto et al., 2022; Eusebio, 2025; Derhab & Elkhwesky, 2023). Trust, strong networks, and shared values further strengthen community engagement, participation, and equitable access to resources (Lansing et al., 2023; Shabbir & Batool, 2025). Similarly, strategies such as fair pricing, product diversification, technology adoption, and

collaboration have been shown to improve revenue, market reach, and competitiveness despite financial and operational constraints (Apaokueze et al., 2025).

Locally, Madulid (2025) found that medium enterprises in Northern Samar adopt sustainable practices across environmental (waste reduction, resource efficiency), economic (cost management, revenue optimization), and social (employee welfare, community engagement) dimensions. These practices improve performance such as community reputation, environmental protection, and operational efficiency, but face challenges like limited resources and high costs. The study recommends circular economy approaches, innovation, and stronger governance to support long-term sustainability.

Green marketing and eco-innovation enhance both sustainability and profitability. Studies shows that green marketing strengthens the connection with their target market and promotes environmental values (Costales et al.,2024; Hernandez et al.,2023). Moreover, eco-innovation, energy conservation, and waste reduction improve economic performance, brand reputation, and consumer loyalty, despite challenges such as high implementation costs and complex regulations (Eusebio & Tibon, 2025; Pasaribu et al.,2024). Additionally, practical energy-saving training helps businesses lower costs and improve sustainability, even when facing challenges like high implementation costs and limited knowledge (Tampubolon et al., 2024).

Sustainability practices help businesses achieve long-term success, and social enterprises play a vital role in supporting communities and promoting sustainable development. However, few studies have examined how social enterprises implement sustainability practices in developing areas like Agusan del Norte. Most existing research focuses on urban settings and traditional businesses rather than social enterprises, even though social enterprises play an important role in creating social impact. Social enterprises in developing areas operate under different conditions, which may affect how sustainability practices are applied. This study aims to fill this gap by

assessing how social enterprises in Agusan del Norte implement sustainability practices and how these practices influence their performance outcomes.

The main objective of this study is to assess the sustainability practices of social enterprises in Agusan del Norte, focusing on the economic, social, and environmental dimensions. Specifically, it aims to determine how these sustainability practices influence the enterprises' performance outcomes in terms of operational efficiency, community reputation, and environmental protection. The findings of the study will provide insights and practical strategies to help social enterprises strengthen their sustainability practices, thereby promoting inclusive and sustainable local development.

The study examines how sustainability practices are implemented by social enterprises in Agusan del Norte. Social enterprises can benefit directly from the results by improving strategies that promote responsible operations and long-term sustainability. Local communities may benefit through better livelihood opportunities and wider access to sustainable programs. Policymakers and local organizations can use the findings to develop programs and support business growth and sustainability in underserved communities. Moreover, this study will benefit the College of Business Management by providing practical insights that support teaching, research, and community programs promoting responsible and sustainable business practices. Finally, the study contributes to the academic field by providing a basis for future research on rural social enterprises and sustainable development.

1.2 Review of Related Literature

This chapter discusses the relevant literature for the study, providing a thorough review of existing research that supports the variables being examined. Its main purpose is to place the study in the wider context of social enterprise sustainability practices by reviewing previous findings and identifying knowledge gaps that this research aims to fill.

Social Enterprise

Social enterprises help communities by combining business and social goals. They create jobs, support low-income people, and promote sustainable development (Toheeb et al., 2025). These organizations also help vulnerable sectors, such as people experiencing homelessness, by providing employment opportunities, training, and community participation. In doing so, they serve as a bridge between short-term relief and long-term rehabilitation, even while facing challenges such as limited funding and policy gaps (Bharti & Bhatia 2025).

According to the OECD, a social enterprise is mainly created to serve the public and achieve social or economic goals rather than maximize profit. Even though definitions may differ slightly, they all highlight the same idea: social enterprises exist to address social problems. Their roles include: (1) providing stable and meaningful employment to vulnerable groups; (2) supporting and investing in local communities to improve quality of life; and (3) helping deliver government programs and financial assistance to those most in need. These roles show that social enterprises contribute to both economic development and social welfare at the same time (Park & Kim, 2020).

Alongside these roles, social enterprises have distinct characteristics that set them apart from traditional businesses. They operate with strong social or environmental objectives, generate income through their own business activities, and reinvest most of their profits back into their mission to ensure long-term sustainability (Giant Leap, 2025). Many social enterprises also adopt

inclusive, community-based structures. For example, cooperatives are member-owned and aim to improve the well-being of all their members rather than focus solely on profit. These characteristics highlight transparency, shared responsibility, ethical practices, and community participation making social enterprises people-centered and socially driven (Lu, 2024).

In the Philippines, social enterprises play a crucial role in addressing inequality, unemployment, and poverty. They support farmers, fishermen, indigenous peoples, and urban poor communities by offering sustainable livelihoods, fair trade opportunities, and access to essential services. Guided by the Filipino value of bayanihan, these enterprises reinvest their earnings to strengthen long-term community impact and promote inclusive development. Cooperatives contribute significantly because they empower marginalized groups, strengthen local livelihoods, and support sustainable development. Meanwhile, the government helps ensure sustainability by offering legal support, funding opportunities, and capacity-building programs. Through these collective efforts, social enterprises are able to grow, thrive, and contribute to meaningful and lasting social change in the country (Lu, 2024).

Sustainability Practices

Sustainability includes protecting the environment, treating people fairly, and keeping the business financially stable. It recognizes that companies have responsibilities not only to their investors but also to the whole community. These three pillars are the foundation of sustainable business practices and show the shift from focusing only on profit to a more balanced and long-term way of managing a business (Maheshwari, 2024).

Sustainability practices are increasingly emphasized as enterprises address environmental, social, and economic demands. Environmental practices—such as proper waste disposal, recycling, and resource efficiency, help reduce ecological impact. Social practices, including supportive employee policies, workplace safety, and community involvement, promote well-being

and social responsibility. Economic practices, like fair pricing, responsible financial management, and reinvestment, support long-term business stability. Overall, integrating these sustainability practices enhances enterprise resilience, strengthens performance, and contributes to community development (Madulid, 2025).

Sustainable practices matter for more than just doing good; they shape a company's identity, influence customer perception, and guide investor decisions. By integrating these practices, businesses enhance their performance and strengthen community ties. Today, sustainability is not only the right choice, it is essential for long-term success in a competitive global market (Maheshwari, 2024).

Economic Sustainability Practices

Sustainable economic practices play an important role in the existence and growth of social enterprises. Several studies have shown that having access to capital and effective financial management help enterprises to be stable. It was emphasized by Adeyini et al. (2025) that microfinance has a significant contribution to poverty reduction and the growth of entrepreneurship, especially in regions with limited access to formal banking systems. They found that providing microcredit, organized savings programs, and business advisory support helped increase income and improve business operations. Similarly, Nurchayati et al. (2025) found that government support, profit reinvestment, and credit risk management have a significant impact on the long-term survival of MSMEs. Of these, the reinvestment of profits has the greatest impact, showing that smart financial management within the business is crucial for success.

According to van der Horst and van Uchelen (2025), social enterprises can use legal policies and structures to focus their operation on their social purpose. Limiting the distribution of income helps to direct more funds to social causes and encourages the active participation of employees and beneficiaries. It is also emphasized that having sufficient financial resources is

important to attract capital investors. However, Abdelrahman et al. (2020) pointed out that microfinance still has high transaction costs, which cause an increase in interest rates, but many small enterprises (SMEs) still rely on it despite these limitations. These studies show that finance is both a strength and a challenge for small enterprises.

Beyond financial management, enterprises also use different strategies to remain competitive. It was discovered by Apaokueze et al. (2025) that small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) that use strategies such as fair pricing, offering a variety of products, using new technologies, and collaborating with other enterprises have experienced a dramatic increase in revenue, market expansion, and stronger competitiveness. This shows that financial management and strategic planning are very important to maintain business growth and its impact on society. Pshenychna and Zaites (2025) also revealed that many enterprises today use algorithmic, demand-based, and hybrid pricing methods to increase their profits. The study also explains that strategies such as subscription and freemium pricing help companies retain their customers longer and generate higher profits.

Cai (2024) analyzed the management methods, economic sustainability, and growth strategies of SMEs in Shandong Province. The study found that financial management is the most important, followed by operational and strategic management. Key factors contributing to economic sustainability include market diversification and expansion, sustainable management of resources, and financial stability along with sound risk management. It was also determined that the relationship between management methods and growth strategies is generally weak, although the relationship of strategic management with innovation is slightly stronger. The study recommended that governments, industry associations, financial institutions, SME owners, and investors should promote sustainable resource management, diversification, strategic partnerships, and innovation.

Innovation plays an important role in improving business sustainability and performance. Social enterprises often diversify their products and use environmental innovations to meet both economic and social goals. Jha et al. (2021) explained that social enterprises choose their product diversification strategies based on the degree of relatedness of the products and the expected impact, which affects both social and financial goals. These findings indicate that smart pricing and product selection not only increase profits but also support the mission of social enterprises.

Economic sustainability in social enterprises depends on effective financial management, access to capital, strategic planning, innovation, and diversification. The integration of these activities helps enterprises maintain stability, grow profits, and achieve social goals. These findings show that financial and operational strategies are very important to sustain both business performance and social goals.

Environmental Sustainability Practices

Environmental sustainability practices are methods used by social enterprises to protect the environment while conducting their business. These include recycling, saving water and electricity, using renewable energy, producing eco-friendly products, and spreading environmental awareness among customers. Such activities not only help protect the environment but also help the business to be more efficient, have a good reputation, and be competitive.

Studies show that small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) have difficulty implementing environmental practices. Discovered by Charles et al. (2021) that waste collection and recycling businesses in Tanzania face a lack of funding, poor working conditions, and negative public perception; however, they are able to adapt through good management, teamwork, learning new skills, reinvesting profits, and joining cooperatives. Similarly, Derhab and Elkhwesky (2023) noted that MSMEs often lack knowledge, training, and financial resources, which may

prevent their adoption of sustainable practices. Despite these obstacles, proper waste management improves economic performance, competitiveness, and long-term sustainability.

Awareness of environmental issues is increasing as more companies realize the need to reduce their impact on the environment. Tiwari (2024) found that awareness of environmental issues is increasing as more companies realize the need to reduce their impact on the environment. However, the implementation of sustainable practices varies greatly among SMEs, affected by factors such as industry sector, location, and organizational culture. This shows that although many SMEs prioritize sustainability, their ability to implement such activities depends on their resources and internal focus. The study also cited major obstacles to full sustainability, including limited financial resources, lack of technical skills, and weak policies. To overcome these challenges, the study suggested strengthening support from government and institutions, expanding educational and training programs, and encouraging stakeholder collaboration to advance efforts for sustainability at the local level.

Government policies and incentives also play an important role. Emphasized by Sadiq et al. (2022) that stakeholders and policymakers encourage small businesses to adopt environmentally responsible practices because it contributes to economic success. Mentioned by Hernandez et al. (2023) that green marketing strategies help social enterprises engage with their target audience while promoting sustainability. Similarly, Tampubolon et al. (2024) found that practical training in energy-saving work and effective use of equipment allows businesses to reduce costs and improve their sustainability. Furthermore, (Noranarttakun & Pharino, 2021) noted that incentives such as financial support and certificates for green products further push small businesses to adopt eco-friendly innovations.

Using methods for environmental sustainability has clear benefits. It was shown by Pasaribu et al. (2024) that businesses that have implemented an eco-friendly model save energy,

reduce waste, and use renewable materials, thus improving their reputation and attracting loyal customers. Similarly, Kulkarni et al. (2025) that by using modern tools such as data analysis, artificial intelligence, and renewable energy technologies, businesses can improve their decision making and increase operational efficiency. These eco-friendly strategies not only reduce environmental impact but also increase revenue, strengthen reputation, and support long-term growth, showing how sustainability can be key to business success. Also mentioned by Ngo et al. (2024) that SMEs can also compete successfully in the global market by adopting environmentally responsible practices.

In terms of environmental and economic impact, Cagalawan et al. (2025) that proper management of energy, water, chemicals, and waste can improve the financial performance of SMEs. However, challenges such as limited resources, weak support from the government, and regulatory issues remain. Lee, Chung, and Cho (2023) observed that more efficient companies with higher profit margins are more likely to invest in environmental management practices that reduce waste and pollution. Likewise, Costales (2024) also mentioned that businesses that use renewable energy, recyclable materials, and environmentally friendly marketing strategies usually achieve higher profits and maintain competitiveness.

Local studies support these findings. Alamer et al. (2025) reported that social enterprises in Camarines Sur, Philippines, are actively including eco-friendly initiatives and renewable energy into their business strategies, linking environmental protection with their social and economic goals. Despite challenges such as pollution reduction, biodiversity conservation, financial instability, unclear regulation, and the use of technology, businesses continue to carry out sustainable practices. Strategies such as circular economy models, multi-stakeholder collaboration, digital literacy programs, and mentorship networks further strengthen sustainability outcomes.

Ultimately, innovation is essential for environmental sustainability. Eco-innovation, including eco-friendly products, environmentally friendly processes, and green marketing, improves environmental, social, and financial outcomes. However, its effectiveness depends on the size of the company, type of industry, and country of operation. SMEs may face unique challenges in adopting eco-innovation, especially in the service sector (Eusebio, 2025). These findings show that while eco-innovation boosts long-term sustainability, appropriate methods are needed to maximize the benefits in different business contexts.

Environmental sustainability practices enable social enterprises to reduce environmental impact while improving operational efficiency, reputation, and competitiveness. The use of eco-friendly methods, supported by government policies, financial incentives, and eco-innovation, allows SMEs to achieve long-term environmental, social, and economic benefits. These practices are important to maintain a balance of business purpose and environmental responsibility, especially in developing economies.

Social Sustainability Practices

Social practices are important to social enterprises because they help people, strengthen communities, and support sustainable development. These activities include fair hiring, providing effective training to workers, supporting local communities, and implementing inclusive policies. This allows businesses to focus not only on profits but also on creating real benefits for society. Many recent studies show that social enterprises can have a positive impact, even with some challenges.

Many studies have focused on how social enterprises bring about positive change through their structure and activities. Kiss et al. (2022) show that people benefit by providing essential services, creating employment opportunities, and strengthening community support. Efforts to address social injustice and ensure employee welfare demonstrate a dedication to inclusive and

ethical business management (Cristobal-Cipriano, Arroyo, & Romualdo, 2022). However, they also emphasize that external problems, such as lack of funding and policy issues, can affect the long-term success of social enterprises.

Social sustainability projects foster community participation, skill development, and long-term societal well-being. Bharti and Bhatia (2025) found that social entrepreneurship provides employment opportunities, skills training, and avenues for community participation to homeless people, linking short-term assistance to long-term rehabilitation. Similarly, Teng-Calleja et al. (2023) that rural social enterprises improve local economic conditions, enhance quality of life, and promote environmental protection. Social enterprises strengthen communities by developing skills, teaching positive values, strengthening cultural norms, and fostering interpersonal relationships. These findings provide valuable insights for policy making, community programs, and leadership development.

Sustainable leadership is also important for social enterprises, especially community-based social enterprises (CBSEs). It was emphasized by Suriyankietkaew et al. (2022) that effective leaders use strategic planning, systems thinking, ethical behavior, foresight, and interpersonal skills to maintain stability during a crisis like COVID-19. Supporting employees and stakeholders, promoting ethical values, fostering social relationships through innovation, and encouraging environmentally and socially responsible practices contribute to achieving inclusive growth, long-term sustainability, and organizational stability.

Inclusive policies and support systems further strengthen social impact. Discovered by Lestari et al. (2025) that employment acceptance among MSMEs depends on policies, education, and economic conditions, where a higher minimum wage boosts employment and worker welfare. Similarly, Banik and Debbarma (2024) showed that MSMEs in India expand employment opportunities, ensure equitable distribution of industry in different regions, and encourage

women's participation in entrepreneurship, demonstrating the social and economic benefits of inclusive practices. Moreover, Cooperatives also support community well-being by helping small farmers, improving access to resources, and promoting sustainable farming, which contributes to food security and economic stability (Ishak et al., 2025).

Workplace social activities have a direct impact on employee performance and organizational sustainability. Devcota, Rai, and Sharma (2025) found that when employees are motivated, engaged in activities, and treated according to their individual needs, they provide better service and are more likely to stay with the company longer. Additionally, Sun et al. (2024) that corporate social responsibility (CSR) contributes to business growth by strengthening trust, improving image, and creating a more positive workplace. Recruiting local people from host communities and giving them knowledge about environmental protection demonstrates socially grounded CSR (Cristobal-Cipriano, Arroyo, & Romualdo, 2022).

Social enterprise sustainability practices, from inclusive hiring and workplace participation to community support, leadership, and CSR, strengthen community well-being, develop skills, and contribute to long-term social and economic development. The effective integration of these activities ensures that enterprises achieve their social goals while maintaining organizational stability and promoting sustainable development.

Community Reputation

The reputation of the community is one of the most important results of the sustainability activities of social enterprises. It refers to how people in the community view and trust a social enterprise. The study shows that trust is an important factor for effective community participation, in promoting equality, in building a safe environment, and in implementing practices that are sensitive to each other's experiences. Practical strategies such as meeting people “where they are,” promoting openness and honesty, creating shared goals, and addressing systemic inequities

help strengthen trust between agencies and community members. Strongly fostering trust in turn leads to better community participation, equitable access to resources, and overall community well-being (Lansing et al., 2023).

Several factors within an organization also affect a community enterprise's ability to build and maintain a good reputation. The performance of a community enterprise is influenced by several important factors. Strategic marketing helps enterprises identify opportunities and keep up with market changes, while green supply chain activities improve reputation and customer loyalty. Innovation provides competitiveness, and organizational learning strengthens skills and knowledge sharing. Through social entrepreneurship, business goals and social goals are align, and analyzing the destination's vulnerability strengthens resilience and long-term sustainability. Collectively, these factors support better performance, sustainable development, and positive outcomes for the community and environment (Pranee et al., 2024).

Social enterprises play an important role in the development and recognition of communities, especially for those at the edges of society. Through activities such as providing information, providing protection, strengthening relationships, providing support, and normalizing experiences, enterprises like Familyship help community members overcome social challenges, build a shared identity, and strengthen relationships within the community. These efforts increase the credibility and social status of the enterprise in the community, demonstrating their contribution to the promotion of social inclusion and general well-being of the community (Ottlewski, 2021).

Establishing relationships and gaining acceptance from the community is also important in strengthening a community's reputation. It was shown by Khiawnoi et al. (2025) that entrepreneurs who form partnerships and networks make their organizations more stable and develop innovation and resilience. Similarly, Shabbir and Batool (2025) emphasized that trust,

relationships, and shared community values are essential for social entrepreneurship to succeed and be sustainable. Strengthening these relationships will help grow community support and improve the overall impact of the enterprise, especially in developing countries.

Values are another factor that shapes reputation. Chatterjee (2021) suggested that social entrepreneurs actively engage in shared values to guide their activities and promote positive social change. By properly understanding and using these values, they develop the ability to deal with conflicts and promote sustainable change within the community. Important tasks include showing concern for employees and stakeholders, promoting moral values, strengthening social relations through social innovation, and supporting environmentally and socially responsible activities to achieve development, long-term sustainability, and stability (Suriyankietkaew et al., 2022).

Overall, community reputation is shaped by trust, organizational strategies, partnerships, shared value, and sustainable practices. Social enterprises that actively practice them not only strengthen their credibility and social status but also strengthen community participation, promote equality, and improve overall well-being. These findings demonstrate the importance of reputation management for the sustainability and effectiveness of social enterprises.

Environmental Protection

Environmental protection is a major result of environmental activities in enterprises. This includes reducing harm to the environment while maintaining responsible business practices. Studies show that companies with efficient operations and higher profits are more willing to invest in environmental management systems that reduce pollution and waste (Lee, Chung, & Cho, 2023).

Environmentally sustainable practices promote innovation that helps preserve nature. Study findings show that having a solid eco-innovation strategy is essential to the successful implementation of various types of eco-innovation, which has a positive impact on environmental

outcomes and overall business performance. This indicates that strategic planning regarding eco-innovation not only supports sustainability goals but also helps improve business results. The study emphasizes that managers can use eco-innovation strategies to enhance operational efficiency, reduce negative environmental impact, and achieve higher levels of performance (Kafetzopoulos et al., 2024).

Besides eco-innovation strategies, entrepreneurship plays an important role in promoting sustainable business practices. Many entrepreneurs today are using green business models, such as recycling systems, eco-friendly innovations, and sustainable supply chains, to reduce waste, save resources, and reduce carbon emissions. However, there are challenges such as lack of market support, strict regulations, and limited funding that make the growth of such activities difficult. Technology and innovation, such as renewable energy and data-driven tools, are important to improve and make green business solutions more effective (Odeyemi et al., 2024).

Community involvement and marketing strategies are also connected to environmental protection. Social enterprises are increasingly using digital platforms and green marketing to promote eco-friendly activities, engage the local community, and support broader sustainability goals (Hernandez et al., 2023). Small and medium enterprises (SMEs) in the City of Muntinlupa, Philippines, are implementing strategies such as promoting eco-friendly products, using green technologies, using renewable energy, and including recyclable materials. Such activities not only strengthen the sustainability and profitability of the business but also help protect the environment for future generations. Including green marketing into sustainable business practices allows businesses to achieve long-term operational success while positively contributing to the environment (Costales et al., 2024).

Environmental protection in social enterprises involves the use of eco-friendly practices, encouraging innovation, and community involvement. These strategies not only reduce negative

environmental impact but also improve operational efficiency, profitability, and long-term sustainability. Understanding such activities is important for social enterprises in Agusan del Norte to achieve both environmental and economic goals while benefiting their community.

Operational Efficiency

Operational efficiency refers to the effectiveness of how a social enterprise uses its resources, manages processes, and achieves its goals. Implementation of environmental management practices is important to improve efficiency. Lee, Chung, and Cho (2023) found that companies with higher operational efficiency and profit margins are more likely to implement environmental management practices. Similarly, Oduro and Haylemariam (2025) showed that SMEs that use sustainability practices, such as eco-friendly models and technologies, improve their operational performance and competitiveness. Kulkarni et al. (2025) also emphasized that eco-friendly practices not only increase profits but also improve operational efficiency and strengthen reputation, helping businesses maintain their competitive edge.

Strategies and innovations are central to achieving operational efficiency. Cho, Kim, and Oh (2022) discovered that the sustainability of social enterprises is shaped by their strategic orientation, practical management, and altruistic values. Specifically, strategic orientation and practicality strengthen dynamic capabilities, while strategic orientation and altruism improve organizational effectiveness. In this way, both dynamic capabilities and organizational effectiveness contribute positively to overall sustainability, demonstrating the importance of effective strategy and management for long-term success. Additionally, Ávila et al. (2021) found that social enterprises that emphasize their social mission tend to develop operational capabilities that help more effectively manage resources and improve overall efficiency. These studies show that operational efficiency depends not only on internal processes but also on strategic direction, innovation, and involvement in social causes.

Financial Management is another important factor that supports efficiency. It was shown by Adeyini et al. (2025) that micro-enterprises benefit greatly from microfinance services, including microcredit, structured savings programs, and business advisory support, which contribute to higher profit margins and improved operational efficiency. These findings show that microfinance not only provides financial resources but also serves as a strategic enabler to sustain business operations and grow profits. Pshenychna and Zaiets (2025) noted that pricing strategies such as algorithmic, demand-based, and subscription/freemium models help businesses optimize revenue and improve long-term customer retention. Additionally, Nurchayati et al. (2022) that the government's effective financial management, internal financial practices such as profit reinvestment, and credit risk monitoring are important to ensure the long-term survival of the business.

Operational efficiency in social enterprises is shaped by effective management of resources, strategic direction, innovation, and financial management. By improving internal processes, using financial and strategic tools, and implementing eco-friendly practices, businesses can increase their productivity, reduce costs, and boost overall sustainability. Combining operational efficiency with environmental and social initiatives ensures long-term organizational success and positive community impact.

Age

Age is an important part of the demographic profile because it affects the way people understand and act regarding sustainability. Younger individuals, especially those with a higher level of education, are more aware and more concerned about environmental issues compared to those who are older and have a lower level of education (Alam & Zakaria, 2021). Moreover, age also affects the creation of social value in the field of entrepreneurship. Brieger et al. (2021) found a U-shaped relationship between the age of entrepreneurs and their goals in creating social value,

which means that younger and older entrepreneurs are more focused on social goals, while middle-aged ones are more focused on economic goals.

Older people also help in environmental activities. Studies show that older people are more likely to take part in environmental activities, and living in countries with a higher number of elderly citizens encourages everyone to act more sustainably. In fact, older adults tend to be even more active in environmental initiatives when they live in societies with many other elderly individuals, suggesting that a growing elderly population can positively contribute to environmental protection (Wang et al., 2021).

Furthermore, each generation's responds differently to green marketing and recycling. Generation Z does not easily trust companies that pretend to be environmentally friendly. Millennials and Generation X, on the other hand, are more likely to take part in sustainable action if it is affordable and easy for them to do. Baby Boomers trust well-known brands and traditional media more (Conley et al., 2025).

In sum, age plays an important role in shaping sustainability awareness, creating social value, and addressing environmental issues. Younger and older individuals tend to emphasize social goals, whereas middle-aged individuals value economic goals more. Moreover, generational differences also affect how environmental initiatives are received, which shows the need to have specific strategies to promote environmental and social responsibility.

Sex

Sex is an important factor that can influence an individual’s attitudes and behaviors, including how they understand and participate in environmental or sustainability activities. According to the study by Setiawan et al. (2023), women have higher knowledge about the environment, are more aware of issues related to sustainability, and behave more often with concern for nature compared to men. This shows why it is important to include gender in

participants' demographic information, as it can influence how different people support sustainability.

In social enterprises, sex can also affect the way decisions are made. According to Fernandez-Muiños et al. (2022), women in leadership are more focused on social impact and long-term goals, whereas men are more focused on efficiency and profit. Having a balanced number of men and women in leadership helps to balance these priorities. Businesses with more women in senior positions generally perform better, especially in aspects such as environmental protection, social responsibility, and good governance (Estébanez & Fernandez-Guadaño, 2025).

However, women social entrepreneurs still face challenges. Zhao, Lee, and Ellenwood (2021) found that women have fewer opportunities than men in obtaining funding for social ventures. Similarly, Taferner and Leitner (2025) show that female teams and gender-diverse groups are more likely to establish social ventures, but this still does not reduce the gender bias in obtaining external funding. These results show that social entrepreneurship alone is not enough to completely remove gender-based barriers.

Despite this, the role of women in promoting sustainability is still very important. According to Sahu and Kannoujia (2025), female leaders help businesses become more sustainable. They promote ethical decisions, environmental protection, and social responsibility. Even if they face challenges such as gender bias, having more women in leadership can improve business performance and make companies more environmentally and humane.

Overall, sex has a significant influence on participation in sustainability, with women having higher awareness and dedication to environmental activities. Gender diversity in leadership improves decision-making, balances social and economic goals, and strengthens overall organizational performance. However, it is still important to address gender-based barriers,

especially in obtaining funding, to further expand women's contribution to social entrepreneurship.

Job Position

The positions of employees in social enterprises are important in how the organization reaches its sustainability goals. Leaders play a key role by integrating sustainability into organizational culture by demonstrating sustainable practices, promoting innovation, and aligning the company's vision with environmental and social goals (Anyan et al., 2025). Environmentally committed leaders serve as role models, guiding the organization toward effective sustainability management and showing how leadership directly impacts organizational outcomes (Kiel et al., 2024).

Employee participation is also important. When staff actively participate in making decisions, contribute to sustainability initiatives, and provide feedback, they become the drivers of change. They help organization use sustainable practices and reach bigger goals such as climate action, social equity, and economic development (Anyan et al., 2025). Combining employee participation with sustainable business practices makes organization stronger, promotes new ideas, and supports global sustainability goals like United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) (Anyan et al., 2025). Furthermore, founders and managers is also important in shaping the workforce by strategically recruiting individuals whose values, attitudes, knowledge, and skills are aligned with the mission and goals of the social enterprise. Using different ways of hiring helps organization find employee who can support sustainability efforts and help the enterprise grow (Teves et al., 2020).

The positions of leaders, managers, and employees are important in bringing sustainability in social enterprises. With good leadership, active employee participation, and strategic recruitment, an organization can build a strong culture of innovation and accountability. These

combined efforts enable social enterprises to achieve long-term sustainability and have a significant impact on social, environmental, and economic goals.

Years of Operation

The number of years a social enterprise has been operating plays an important role in shaping its financial sustainability and overall impact. Two recent studies by Iqmal et al. (2022) and Ong and Tan (2025) explain on how length of operation affects the financial management practices and performance of social enterprises. Although their learning methods differ, they both emphasize the importance of experience in organizational success.

Iqmal et al. (2022) focused on how longer years of operation contribute to stronger financial management practices. Their research shows that social enterprises with more operational experience, larger organizational size, and higher profitability on own income are better at managing their finances. Similarly, Ong and Tan (2025) examined social enterprises operating for more than five years to determine how their social mission relates to economic and financial outcomes. They found that strong social enterprises typically balance community impact and financial results, and that a strong focus on their social mission positively affects metrics such as Return on Assets (ROA) and Return on Equity (ROE).

The number of years of operation is important in determining the success of social enterprises. Organizations with longer operating experience are more effectively able to manage finances and balance social and economic goals. As a result, strong social enterprises are more likely to achieve sustainable growth and long-term impact.

1.3 Theoretical Framework

Triple Bottom Line (TBL) Theory

The Triple Bottom Line (TBL) Theory, introduced by John Elkington (1997) in his book Cannibals with Forks: The Triple Bottom Line of 21st Century Business, According to this theory, business success should not rely solely on financial results but also on social and environmental performance. This theory presents sustainability through three interconnected dimensions. People (Social Responsibility) involves fair labor practices, employee welfare, and community engagement. Planet (Environmental Responsibility) focuses on resource conservation, reducing carbon emissions, and proper waste management. Profit (Economic Viability) emphasizes long-term financial stability while considering social and environmental responsibilities (Saleh & Azimi, 2025).

The Triple Bottom Line (TBL) framework influences business performance by integrating economic, social, and environmental dimensions, helping organizations address socio-environmental challenges and achieve long-term sustainability (Nogueira et al., 2025). Sustainability practices directly shape performance outcomes such as community reputation, operational efficiency, and environmental protection. Strong social practices enhance community and customer recognition, improving community reputation. Effective environmental practices help organizations comply with regulations, reduce pollution, and strengthen environmental protection. Economic sustainability practices promote better customer satisfaction and more efficient use of resources, improving operational efficiency (Madulid, 2025).

TBL is important in this study because it provides a framework to examine how social enterprises in Agusan del Norte implement sustainability practices and achieve specific performance outcomes. In this research, the independent variables are economic,

environmental, and social practices, while the dependent variables are operational efficiency, environmental protection, and community reputation. Guided by TBL framework, this study measures how sustainability practices influence performance outcomes and to systematically evaluate both practices and outcomes.

1.4 Schematic Diagram

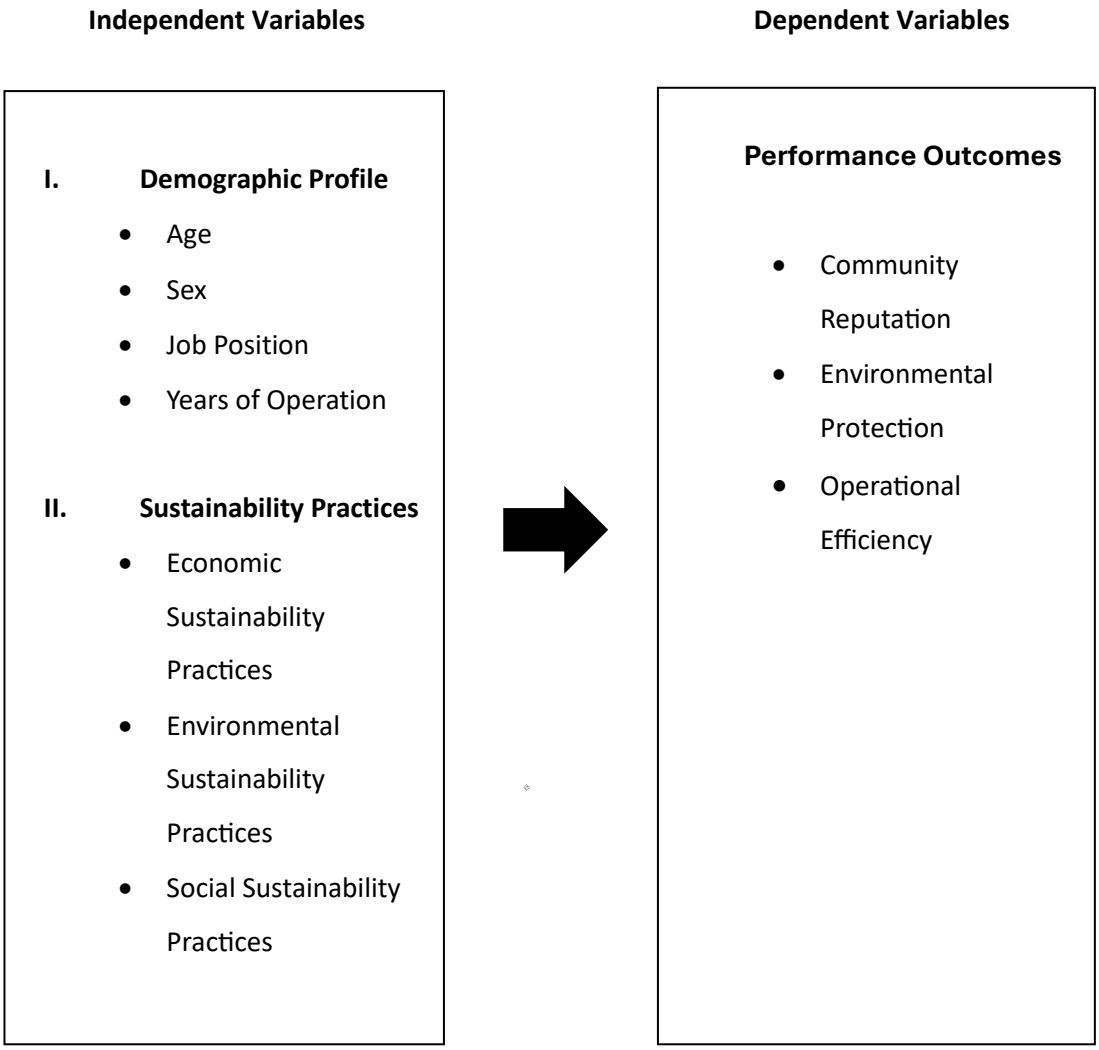


Figure 1: The schematic diagram shows the interplay between the independent and dependent variables of the study.

1.5 Statement of the Problem

This study examines the sustainability practices of social enterprises in Buenavista and Carmen.

Specifically, this study aims to answer the following questions:

1. What is demographic profile of respondents in terms of:

    1.1 Age;

    1.2 Sex;

    1.3 Job Position; and

    1.4 Years of Operation?

2. To what extent social enterprises implement sustainability practices in terms of:

    2.1 Economic Sustainability Practices;

    2.2 Environmental Sustainability Practices; and

    2.3 Social Sustainability Practices?

3. To what extent the performance outcomes in terms of:

    3.1 Community Reputation;

    3.2 Environmental Protection; and

    3.3 Operational Efficiency?

4. Is there a significant relationship between the level of sustainability practices implemented by social enterprises and their performance outcomes?

1.6 Hypothesis

Null Hypothesis(H_o)

H_o: There is no significant relationship between the level of sustainability practices implemented by social enterprise and their performance outcomes in Buenavista and Carmen, Province of Agusan del Norte.

1.7 Scope and Limitations

This research will examine the sustainability practices and performance outcomes of social enterprises in the municipalities of Buenavista and Carmen, province of Agusan del Norte. Both staff and active members of the social enterprises will participate in the study. The study will be conducted in the academic year 2025‑2026.

The study is limited to enterprises operating within Buenavista and Carmen that demonstrate the core characteristics of a social enterprise—such as having a strong social mission, engaging in income-generating activities, and reinvesting profits to support and expand their social mission. Data will be collected using a structured questionnaire adapted and modified from Madulid (2025). As the study is geographically restricted to these two municipalities, the findings may not be fully generalizable to other areas.

1.8 Definition of Terms

This section defines key terms used in the study to ensure clarity and consistency throughout the research.

Age. A demographic variable recorded in whole years based on the respondent's self-reported age in the survey.

Community Reputation. An outcome variable measured through the level of public trust, stakeholder support, consumer confidence, positive media recognition, employee pride, and overall community acceptance of the enterprise.

Economic Sustainability Practices. A component of the sustainability practices variable measured through fair pricing, financial management, cost control, resource efficiency, and income growth.

Environmental Protection. An outcome variable measured through pollution reduction, compliance with environmental laws, resource conservation, renewable energy use, and ecosystem preservation.

Environmental Sustainability Practices. A component of the sustainability practices variable measured through waste management, recycling, resource reduction, eco-friendly materials, and environmental awareness initiatives.

Job Position. A demographic variable referring to the specific role or function held by the respondent within the enterprise.

Operational Efficiency. An outcome variable measured through resource optimization, productivity improvement, cost reduction, streamlined operations, supply chain efficiency, and organizational resilience.

Performance Outcomes. Refers to the measurable results of sustainability practices, assessed through indicators related to community reputation, operational efficiency, and environmental protection.

Sex. A demographic variable identified through the respondent's selected category: male or female.

Social Enterprise. Refers to the type of organization being assessed, specifically enterprises with a social or environmental mission that generate income through trade and reinvest most of their profits to advance that mission.

Social Sustainability Practices. A component of the sustainability practices variable measured through employee welfare programs, community engagement, inclusivity, work-life balance, professional growth, and recognition systems.

Sustainability Practices. The independent variable measured through the economic, environmental, and social practices implemented by the enterprise to support long-term responsible operations.

Years of Operation. A demographic variable referring to the number of years the enterprise has been functioning, based on the respondent's answer in the survey.

CHAPTER 2

METHODOLOGY

This chapter discusses and addresses the principles the researchers adhered to in answering the specific problems posed by the systematic investigation. Specifically, it described the research design, research locale, research respondents, research instrument, ethical standards, data collection procedure, and statistical treatment used.

2.1 Research Design

This study will use a descriptive-correlational quantitative research design to assess the sustainability practices and performance outcomes of social enterprises in Agusan del Norte. The descriptive component will examine the extent of environmental, economic, and social practices, as well as outcomes related to community reputation, operational efficiency, and environmental protection. The correlational component will determine whether significant relationships exist between the level of sustainability practices and performance outcomes. Data will be collected using a 4-point Likert scale and analyzed through frequencies, percentages, weighted means, and Pearson`s correlation.

2.2 Research Locale

The study will be conducted in two (2) municipalities: of Buenavista and Carmen, in the Province of Agusan del Norte, specifically in the Northern Mindanao, where the local economy is largely supported by agriculture, fisheries, and micro, small, and medium enterprises (MSMEs). These areas will be selected because they represent different economic roles in the province. Buenavista is a coastal municipality, has a population of approximately 68,892 and a land area of 475.61 square kilometers (PhilAtlas). It is a growing trade and service center with an economy supported by agriculture, fisheries, and local industries, spanning both coastal and inland areas. Carmen, a coastal municipality, has about 23,172 residents and covers 214.44 square kilometers

(PhilAtlas), with an economy primarily based on agriculture and fisheries, particularly its well-known mango production. These municipalities were selected because they represent different economic roles in the province, providing meaningful insights into how social enterprises in rural communities implement sustainability practices and contribute to local development.

2.3 Research Respondents

The research respondents are the staff and active members from four social enterprises located, in the municipalities of Buenavista and Carmen. Staff offer firsthand knowledge of internal operations, while active members provide perceptual insights from their involvement in meetings, updates, and decision-making. Together, they can give accurate and meaningful responses about the sustainability practices and performance outcomes of their enterprises. Their insights are essential for understanding how these organizations balance economic viability with social and environmental goals. The selected four enterprises were included because they demonstrate the core characteristics of a social enterprise, including a clear social mission, engagement in income-generating activities, and the reinvestment of profits to support and expand their social objectives. The study focuses on four (4) social enterprises:

Enterprise 1: Coffee Products, operates a sustainable coffee enterprise producing and selling locally grown coffee. Guided by its vision of a progressive and unified farming community, it aims to improve members' livelihoods through continuous training, livelihood development, capital growth, family welfare support, and collaboration with partner agencies.

Enterprise 2: Textile Fiber Innovation Hub, empowers over 80 local farmers by converting bamboo into textile-grade fiber. Supported by a guaranteed market partnership with DOST–Philippine Textile Research Institute (DOST–PTRI), it adds value to local bamboo resources, creates sustainable income, and integrates farmers into the textile value chain (Molde, 2025).

Enterprise 3: Coffee Products, is a farmers' organization that seeks to improve members' livelihoods through unity, cooperation, and participation in community development. It enhances agricultural productivity and product distribution through technology adoption, continuous training, capital building, and institutional partnerships. The association also produces and markets value-added products to generate sustainable income for its members.

Enterprise 4: Fruit Processing Center, is a social enterprise that supports local farmers by processing fresh agricultural produce into commercial value-added products. Through strong partnerships with government and development agencies, it generates sustainable income, creates livelihood opportunities, and promotes inclusive rural development (DTI–Agusan del Norte, 2025).

Table 1. Respondents of the Study

Social Enterprise	Population *N*	Sample Size (Frequency)	Percentage *%*
Enterprise 1	43	29	22.31%
Enterprise 2	60	40	30.77%
Enterprise 3	60	40	30.77%
Enterprise 4	31	21	16.15%
Total	**194**	**130**	**100%**

A total of 130 individuals from four social enterprises in municipalities of Buenavista and Carmen will serve as the participants of the study. The respondents were chosen through random sampling from active members and staff of social enterprises. These participants will answer structured survey questionnaires adapted and modified from Madulid (2025) designed to gather information about sustainability practices and outcomes. The data collected will help provide a

deeper understanding of how rural social enterprises in Agusan del Norte promote sustainability in real-world settings.

2.4 Research Instruments

The study will use a survey questionnaire adapted and modified from the study of Madulid (2025), titled *"Assessment of Environmental, Economic, Social, and Sustainable Governance Practices of Medium Enterprises in Northern Samar."* The instrument is designed to assess the sustainability practices and performance outcomes of social enterprises. Responses will be measured using a Likert scale to capture the level of agreement of the respondents with each statement.

The questionnaire is composed of three parts. Part I covers the demographic profile of the respondents, including age, sex, job position, and years of operation of the social enterprise. Part II measures the sustainability practices of social enterprises in terms of economic, environmental, and social dimensions. Part III measures the performance outcomes of the enterprises in terms of community reputation, environmental protection, and operational efficiency.

Parts II and III use a 4-point Likert scale, where respondents indicate their level of agreement with each statement. The scale ranges from Strongly Disagree (1) to Strongly Agree (4). Part II examines the sustainability practices of social enterprises across economic, environmental, and social dimensions, with responses interpreted quantitatively from Never Practiced to Highly Practiced. Part III evaluates the performance outcomes of these practices in terms of community reputation, environmental protection, and operational efficiency, with interpretations ranging from Not Recognized/Committed/Inefficient to Highly Recognized/Committed/Efficient. Higher scores indicate a higher level of practice implementation and stronger performance outcomes. The responses will be interpreted using weighted means to describe the extent of sustainability practices and performance outcomes.

To ensure the validity of the instrument, the questionnaire will undergo content validation by research experts, who will evaluate the clarity, relevance, and alignment of the items with the study's objectives. Their suggestions will be incorporated to improve the instrument. Prior to the actual data collection, a pilot test will be conducted among individuals who are not part of the final sample to assess the clarity and reliability of the questionnaire. Based on the results of the pilot testing, necessary revisions will be made, and the finalized instrument will then be used for the main survey.

2.5 Research Ethical Standards

A. Intellectual Property Rights (IPR)

This study will not involve the development of new inventions or products that require patent protection. The survey questionnaire will be adapted and modified from a published study with permission from its original author. No brand name, logo, or design will be used, so trademark protection is not necessary.

B. Informed Consent

Participants will receive a clear explanation of the study' s purpose, procedures, and possible risks or benefits. They will sign a form to confirm that they understand the information and agree to participate voluntarily. Participants are free to withdraw at any time without any negative consequences. This process ensures that the rights and autonomy of all participants are respected and protected.

C. Data Privacy and Confidentiality

The researchers will keep all participants and enterprises information confidential and secure. Survey responses will remain anonymous, and all data will be safely stored and handled in compliance with data privacy regulations to protect participants' privacy. After the completion of the study, all collected data will be properly disposed of. Hard copies of questionnaires will be

shredded, and electronic files will be permanently deleted. The researchers will be responsible for the safe disposal of all research data.

D. Voluntary Participation

Participation in this study by staff and active members of social enterprises will be entirely voluntary. Participants may choose to stop answering the survey at any time without any consequences if they feel uncomfortable or experience any emotional or physical discomfort. This approach ensures that all participants freely decide to take part and engage with full understanding and willingness.

E. Minimization of Harm

The researchers will ensure no harm to participants of social enterprises. The adapted and modified survey questionnaire will be carefully review to prevent any form of physical, emotional, or mental stress. Participants will be informed of the study' s purpose, procedures, risks, and rights, and support such as emergency contacts and counseling will be available if needed. The survey will be conducted at a time and place convenient to the participants. Questionnaires may be answered in their office or taken home, depending on their preference. If answered in the office, the survey will be completed during non-operational hours or break time to ensure that it does not interfere with their regular work or business operations.

F. Beneficence

This study aims to create a positive impact by providing insights into how social enterprises in Agusan del Norte practice sustainability. The findings will help improve operations and guide future efforts in balancing social, environmental, and economic objectives. After completion, participants may request access to the results to promote transparency and mutual benefit.

G. Justice and Fair Respondent Selection

The researchers will select the staff and active members of social enterprises in Agusan del Norte in a fair and transparent manner. The selection process will be free from bias and will include individuals from different roles and backgrounds. By ensuring that all relevant groups are included and treated equally, the research will uphold fairness and provide a balanced picture of the situation. Participants will be chosen based on the following criteria: (1) they are staff or active members of a social enterprise in Agusan del Norte, (2) they are directly involved in the enterprise activities, and (3) they voluntarily agree to participate in the study.

H. Data Integrity and Accuracy

The researchers will collect and analyze data systematically to ensure accuracy and fairness. Access to responses will be limited to the research team, and issues like missing data or sampling errors will be addressed carefully. Incomplete surveys will be followed up respectfully, and all data will be handled responsibly with findings reported truthfully.

I. Transparency in Reporting

The researchers will report results honestly and clearly, ensuring no data is omitted or altered. All sources will be properly cited, and any limitations or biases will be disclosed. Summaries of the findings may be shared with participants and stakeholders to promote transparency and trust.

J. Use of Patented or Copyrighted Materials

This study will not use any patented tools or products. The survey instrument was adapted and modified from a published study with permission, and all sources and copyrighted materials will be properly cited to ensure ethical use and respect for intellectual property.

K. Ethical Considerations for Animal and Human Trials

This study will involve only human participants, specifically the staff and active members of social enterprises in Agusan del Norte. No animals will be included, so animal ethics clearance is not required. The researchers will ensure participants' safety by informing them of the study's purpose, benefits, and minimal risks. In case of any discomfort, support services such as counseling or emergency contacts will be available. All ethical procedures, including informed consent, will be properly and respectfully observed

L. Responsible Use of AI and Related Technologies

The researchers used AI tools such as Grammarly, QuillBot, ChatGPT, and Microsoft Copilot to improve grammar, clarity, and wording. These tools only assisted the writing process, while all ideas and conclusions were reviewed and finalized by the researchers to ensure accuracy, credibility, and ethical integrity.

M. Ethical Approval

Saint Michael College of Caraga's Institutional Review Board (IRB) will review and approve the study titled "Assessing Sustainability Practices of Social Enterprises in Agusan del Norte," which will attest to its compliance with ethical standards for participant protection, data privacy, and intellectual property rights. The IRB approval process will safeguard the rights and welfare of respondents while upholding the integrity of the research.

2.6 Data Gathering Procedures

With the approval of the relevant authorities, the researcher visited the Department of Trade and Industry offices in Buenavista and Carmen, Agusan del Norte, to obtain important information and documents related to the background of social enterprises. These included business lists and other relevant data, which served as primary sources for the study. The researchers also visited four selected social enterprises to gather additional information, including

the total number of staff and members in each enterprise, which helped provide a clearer understanding of their organizational structure and operations.

Upon receiving consent from the participants, the researcher will personally distribute the survey questionnaires to four social enterprises. Respondents will be given enough time to complete the forms accurately and honestly. Once accomplished, the questionnaires will be retrieved and prepared for analysis. The responses will then be checked, tallied, and interpreted using appropriate statistical tools.

Letter of Approval. The researcher will submit a formal letter of request to the heads of the social enterprises to seek validation of the study and obtain permission to proceed with data collection.

Orientation. The researcher will conduct an orientation session for the participants to explain the purpose of the study and ensure that they understand the ethical agreements and the scope of the research.

Distribution of Informed Consent Form. Informed consent forms will be distributed to participants, serving as agreements that confirm they understand their rights and voluntarily agree to participate in the study. Participants will be informed that they may withdraw from the study at any time without any consequences.

Distribution of Questionnaire. The researcher will personally distribute the survey questionnaires to the participants. Sufficient time will be allotted to allow respondents to answer the questions accurately and honestly.

Retrieval of Questionnaire and Consent Form. After the allotted time, the researcher will personally collect the completed questionnaires and consent forms to prepare for data analysis.

Gathering and Analysis of Data. The data will be collected, checked for completeness, tallied, presented, analyzed, and interpreted using appropriate statistical techniques and tools.

2.7 Data Analysis/Statistical Treatment

Frequency and Percentage Distribution. This method will be used to described the demographic profile of respondents and social enterprises. It will represent data such as, age, sex, job position, and years of operation. It will also summarize the distribution of responses across the indicators for sustainability practices and performance outcomes.

Weighted Mean. This tool will be used to determine the level of sustainability practices across the three sustainability dimensions such as economic, environmental, and social—as well as the performance outcomes, including community reputation, environmental protection, and operational efficiency. This statistical tool helps measure the overall extent to which each practice is implemented and how respondents perceive the outcomes. It provides a quantitative summary of the average response for each indicator, allowing for meaningful comparisons between different practices and outcomes.

Pearson`s Correlation. This tool will be used to determine the relationship between sustainability practices and performance outcomes of social enterprises. It measures the strength and direction of the linear relationship between two variables. Through this analysis, the study will determine whether higher levels of sustainability practices are associated with improved performance outcomes, and determine whether these relationships are statistically significant.

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CURRICULUM VITAE



NAME: SANDARA G. LORETO

ADDRESS: D-6, Talisay, Nasipit, Agusan del Norte

EMAIL: sandaraloreto@gmail.com

Personal Information

Sex : Female

Date of birth : June 01, 2004

Height : 5`4

Weight : 48kg

Civil Status : Single

Educational Attainment

Elementary : Malingin Elementary School

Secondary : Pres. Carlos P. Garcia Technical Vocational School of Fisheries and Arts

Tertiary : Saint Michael College Caraga

Membership/Affiliations

ORGANIZATION	POSITIONS HELD
Junior Financial Executive	**Member**

CURRICULUM VITAE



NAME: MARY ROSE O. CAMANIAN

ADDRESS: District West, Cubi-cubi, Nasipit, Agusan del Norte

EMAIL: maryrosiecamanian@gmail.com

Personal Information

Sex	:	FEMALE
Date of birth	:	November 16, 2003
Height	:	4`11
Weight	:	40kg
Civil Status	:	Single

Educational Attainment

Elementary	:	Talisay Elementary School
Secondary	:	Saint Michael College of Caraga
Tertiary	:	Saint Michael College of Caraga

Membership/Affiliations

ORGANIZATION	POSITIONS HELD
Junior Financial Executive	**Member**

CURRICULUM VITAE



NAME: HAZEL MAE B. DOÑAHAN

ADDRESS: P-4, Cahayagan, Carmen, Agusan del Norte

EMAIL: hazelmaedonahan67@gmail.com

Personal Information

Sex	:	Female
Date of birth	:	October 27, 2004
Height	:	5`4
Weight	:	52kg
Civil Status	:	Single

Educational Attainment

Elementary	:	Sacol Elementary School
Secondary	:	Buenavista Sped High School
Tertiary	:	Saint Michael College of Caraga

Membership/Affiliations

ORGANIZATION	POSITIONS HELD
Junior Financial Executive	**Member**

CURRICULUM VITAE



NAME: KURT RYAN R. EDRADAN

ADDRESS: Barangay 8, Buenavista, Agusan del Norte

EMAIL: ryanedradan989@gmail.com

Personal Information

Sex	:	Male
Date of birth	:	October 22, 2004
Height	:	5`5
Weight	:	80kg
Civil Status	:	Single

Educational Attainment

Elementary	:	Buenavista Sped Elementary School
Secondary	:	Saint Michael College of Caraga
Tertiary	:	Saint Michael College of Caraga

Membership/Affiliations

ORGANIZATION	POSITIONS HELD
Junior Financial Executive	**Member**

CURRICULUM VITAE



NAME: SAMEERA SHANE B. GALLARDO

ADDRESS: Barangay 1, Buenavista, Agusan del Norte

EMAIL: gallardosameerashane@gmail.com

Personal Information

Sex	:	Female
Date of birth	:	October 22, 2004
Height	:	5`5
Weight	:	50kg
Civil Status	:	Single

Educational Attainment

Elementary	:	Cogon Central Elementary School
Secondary	:	Saint Michael College of Caraga
Tertiary	:	Saint Michael College of Caraga

Membership/Affiliations

ORGANIZATION	POSITIONS HELD
Junior Financial Executive	**Member**

CURRICULUM VITAE



NAME: JUDY COR L. HERMOSO

ADDRESS: D-4, Culit, Nasipit, Agusan del Norte

EMAIL: palanghermoso@gmail.com

Personal Information

Sex	:	Female
Date of birth	:	October 16, 2005
Height	:	5`2
Weight	:	42kg
Civil Status	:	Single

Educational Attainment

Elementary	:	Culit Elementary School
Secondary	:	Culit National High School
Tertiary	:	Saint Michael College of Caraga

Membership/Affiliations

ORGANIZATION	POSITIONS HELD
Junior Financial Executive	**Member**